Tools and Techniques: Business Analyst (BA) & Report Analyst (RA)

1. Business Analyst (BA): Tools and Techniques

1.1 Requirements Elicitation Techniques

- Interviews: one-on-one sessions with stakeholders to gather detailed requirements.
- Workshops / JAD sessions (Joint Application Development): group sessions to align multiple stakeholders quickly.
- Surveys and questionnaires: for gathering input from a large stakeholder group efficiently.
- Observation (job shadowing): watching users perform tasks to uncover unstated/implicit requirements.
- Document analysis: reviewing existing policies, manuals, and system documentation.
- Brainstorming: group idea generation for possible solutions or requirements.
- Prototyping: building a mock-up/wireframe to validate requirements with users early.

1.2 Requirements Documentation & Modelling Techniques

- Business Requirements Document (BRD) and Functional Requirements Document (FRD).
- User stories and acceptance criteria (common in Agile projects).
- Use case diagrams: show interactions between actors and a system (UML).
- Process flow diagrams / BPMN: visualise as-is and to-be business processes.
- Context diagrams and data flow diagrams (DFD): show system boundaries and data movement.
- Wireframes / mock-ups: visual representation of a proposed interface.

1.3 Analysis & Prioritisation Techniques

- SWOT analysis: strengths, weaknesses, opportunities, threats.
- PESTLE analysis: political, economic, social, technological, legal, environmental factors.
- MoSCoW prioritization: Must have, Should have, Could have, Won't have.
- Gap analysis: comparing current (as-is) state against desired (to-be) state.
- Root cause analysis: 5 Whys, fishbone (Ishikawa) diagrams.
- Cost-benefit analysis: weighing financial cost of a solution against its expected value.

1.4 Software Tools

- Excel: requirements log, RAID log (Risks, Assumptions, Issues, Dependencies), Requirements Traceability Matrix (RTM).
- Visio / Lucidchart / draw.io: process maps and UML diagrams.
- JIRA / Confluence: backlog management, requirement documentation, sprint tracking.
- Balsamiq / Figma: wireframing and prototyping.
- Tableau: visualising business data and trends to support requirements/analysis discussions with stakeholders.
- PowerPoint: stakeholder presentations and findings summaries.

2. Report Analyst (RA): Tools and Techniques

2.1 Data & Activity Tracking Techniques

- Meeting minutes templates: structured capture of discussion points, decisions, and action items.

- Timesheets / hours logs: recording time spent per activity, per team member, per week.
- RAID logs: tracking risks, assumptions, issues, and dependencies alongside activity records.
- Checklists: ensuring every required field (week, hours, activity, name) is captured consistently.
- Cross-checking: verifying logged hours/activities against calendar invites or meeting recordings.

2.2 Reporting & Presentation Techniques

- Status reports: regular (weekly) summaries of progress, blockers, and next steps.
- Dashboards: visual, at-a-glance summaries of key metrics (hours logged, completion %).
- Trend analysis: tracking how hours/activity change over time across weeks.
- Variance reporting: comparing planned vs. actual hours or deliverables.
- Version control of logs: keeping a clear history so past entries aren't overwritten.

2.3 Software Tools

- Excel: pivot tables, conditional formatting, formulas (SUMIFS, COUNTIFS) to summarise logged hours.
- Word / Google Docs: formatting and distributing meeting minutes.
- Microsoft Teams / SharePoint: central storage and version history for reporting files.
- Power BI / Tableau/Google Sheets charts: visual dashboards for hours and activity trends.
- Google Forms / Microsoft Forms: quick structured data collection from team members.

3. Where BA and RA Tools & Techniques Overlap

- Excel is central to both roles: logs, trackers, and matrices for BA; hours/activity summaries for RA.
- Both rely on structured templates to keep documentation consistent and easy to review.
- Tableau is shared too: BA uses it to visualise business/requirements data for stakeholders; RA uses it to build hours and progress dashboards.
- Both use stakeholder-facing presentation tools (PowerPoint/Word) to communicate findings clearly.
- Core difference: BA techniques focus on eliciting and modelling business requirements; RA techniques focus on capturing and reporting team activity and progress.